

the same court (different judge) and won! So, while German officials go bald from scratching their heads wondering which ruling to uphold, you can stop worrying about being confused about this patent thing! Quite apparently, the lawmakers themselves are just as confused—if not more so!

Want some good news? Fraunhofer's patents will expire in April 2010, after which all MP3 algorithms become public domain! So all you need to do is deal with all the confusion for a little over three years more...

Now, back to LAME! As far as comparisons to Ogg Vorbis, AAC and WMA go, the LAME encoder is found to be seriously lacking. However, because of the popularity of the MP3 format, and the wide acceptance with a majority of audio players (from your TV-top DVD player to your cell phone and even your car audio systems), most of us gladly overlook the compromise on quality and file sizes. Microsoft, meanwhile, has been aggressively pushing its own Windows Media format (WMA/WMV), which has resulted in a lot of devices being both WMA- and MP3-capable. Though Windows Media is free from MP3's patent woes, it isn't open source like LAME.

2.1.4 Speex

www.speex.org

Another product of Xiph.org, Speex is sort of the Ogg Vorbis answer to speech compression. Unlike music, speech is a lot simpler, and requires much lower bitrates to be aurally readable. As a result, it is only natural that a different set of algorithms than the ones used for music can compress speech a lot better.

Speex is open source, and can be added to the Ogg container. It uses a variable bitrate encoding process to provide the best possible quality in combination with the best compression ratio. It was developed mainly for VoIP, and uses a unique packet loss concealment technology that masks dropped UDP packets, to prevent crackling and breaking of voice data.